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**In Search of Cinematic Sacredness:
a Comparative Analysis of mediated construction of
Tibet in Martin Scorsese and Pema Tesden's Films**

In this age where film, like all other art forms, is seemingly challenged by the fact that reality can be replicated instantly with a smartphone button, what Benjamin once described as "the transformation of the superstructure" has now become embedded in everyday life. According to Benjamin, "the present condition of production" is "useful for the formulation of revolutionary demands in the politics of art. (Benjamin, 2007)" This indicates that our task is not only to interpret the aesthetics of captured images but to understand how they function politically and joins the dialectical reproduction of the society. Following Benjamin's idea, we must embrace the transformations and approach film from a materialist standpoint to ask what it can still do today. In an ideal filmic world, signs come with symbols, exchange comes with use value, and rationality comes with religion. In Plate's argument, he states that "diegetic realities of cinema constantly collapse into the afilmic world, supplying both form and content for humans' sacred strivings." Today, the two most dominant film industries, Hollywood and Chinese state-sponsored cinema, both fail to turn the invisible imagination into a visible diegetic world and collapse the diegetic into the filmic – space of real and lived experience. When capitalist

spectacles displace religion, the sacred is understood against the secular, and images are only there to entertain, distract, and amaze; where does the sacred realm go? In this paper, I will center the discussion around contemporary cinematic imaginations and recreations of Tibet by Hollywood directors represented by Martin Scorsese and Tibetan New Wave directors represented by Pema Tseden. Through discussing the motivation behind their creation, sacredness inside the text, and contemporary implications of their works in general, this paper will discuss film's mediating role in modern life by reorganizing a way of precepting the sacred.

Inspired by the screenwriter Melissa Mathison, an American director, Martin Scorsese, an American director, shot the film “Kundun” in 1996 Morocco – to avoid forces from the Chinese government in his storytelling of Tibet and Dalai Lama. The film tells the story of the fourteenth Dalai Lama, from birth to the final moment when he is forced to escape to India to avoid prosecution by the Chinese government. At first glance, the idea of a Western director telling a Tibetan story may seem suspicious – and vulnerable to critique through the lens of Orientalism.

From a storytelling point of view, such an indictment is traceable. Written upfront to commence the film, Scorsese claims, "In war-torn Asia, Tibetans have practiced non-violence for over a thousand years." The statement is by no means valid, as claimed by Chirico: "Dalai Lamas have advocated violence as a means of preserving Tibet and the Buddha Dharma. (Chirico, 2019)" This indicates, to a certain extent, Scorsese's ideal imagination of Tibet and his fall into Orientalism romanticization of Tibet as a pure, clean, and perfect land. In addition, politically, according to Chirico, Gestures were made toward Feudalism in Tibet, but they were insufficient in showing that the Chinese could have a point. In Kundun, feudalism in Tibet is exhibited through little Dalai Lama's growth – he seeks reforms, such as rejecting unnecessary etiquette

between himself and the monks. Still, Scorsese did not criticize the feudal system but made minor the issue by focusing on Dalai's personal growth. His portrayal of Chairman Mao further reflects this tendency: Mao appears as a caricature filled with Marxist clichés and devoid of historical complexity, which raised questions about the film's treatment of cross-cultural political entanglements. I have always had a strong affection towards films that are originated from, created by, and delivered to the same cultural group of people and rendered such as authenticity. In this case, however, the endeavor of this American director in search of meaning from oriental regions is then a production originated from Tibet, by both Tibetan and American and for American audiences.

Despite all Orientalism nitpicking on Kundun, compared to other contemporary directors' work, such as "Seven Years in Tibet," which depicts a lost Westerner discovering sacredness and redemption in the imagined Tibet, Scorsese follows a comparatively more authentic representation of the Dalai Lama's biography. What does it mean for a film to mediate the sacred across cultural boundaries? Moreover, do both films rely on Tibet as a mediating image through which the West contemplates its desire for transcendence?

Pema Tseden's film provides a comparison from another point of view – a perspective from the locals, with anxieties reflected upon the prevalence of modernity in Tibet. Pema Tseden was born in Hainan Tibetan Autonomous Prefecture of Qinghai Province. He holds a strong cultural memory for the Tibetan people. It would then be safe to say that films by Pema Tseden are from Tibet, by Tibetan, and for Tibet. In his first film, "The Silent Holy Stone," Pema Tseden tells the story of a little monk's journey back to the village where his family lives. During the visit, he witnessed the permeation of modern culture in the Tibetan region. Things like DVD

players, television, broadcast players, and snacks from modern Han culture seem incompatible with what Westerners in the 90s imagined as “holiness” in Tibetan culture.

"Focalizer," as Bal suggests, is an agent that indicates the vision that offers a perspective for the viewer (Bal, 1995), which is crucial in understanding Pema Tseden's directorial intention and blocking voyeurism. In this film, the young monk serves as the focalizer, portrayed as both wise and youthful. The film opens with him reciting scriptures in the monastery while eagerly anticipating watching a DVD with the living Buddha – another child monk. This highlights the intersection of tradition and curiosity towards modernity. After the little monk travels back to his hometown for the spring festival, he becomes intrigued by the brand-new television in his home, which plays "Journey to the West." The little monk also heard his brother reading a Chinese textbook and heard from him a dream to go to big cities. The little monk expresses his love and curiosity in all his witness of modernity in Tibet. However, when he hears his younger brother enthusiastically praising the wonders of Han culture's math lessons, he proudly talks about Tibetan astronomical and calendrical calculations. Overall, he makes his judgment. Though he enjoys watching television, as a monk, he prefers Journey to the West, which depicts a monk's journey to acquire Buddhist truth and deliberately avoids TV dramas that depict secular romantic relationships.

In Scorsese and Pema Tseden's depiction of early 20th-century Tibet, Durkheimian defined sacred and transcendence as constructed in different manners. According to Siefert, in her book chapter discussing the lost imperialism in the 20th century United States, Shangri-La is a place of unrivaled peace and the wisdom lost to Western modernity in the wake of both the Great War and the Depression (Siefert, 2015). After experiencing the loss of faith in humanity



and the capitalism bubble, Shangri-La, Tibet, and the imagination of transcendence in the Far East becomes the perfect place for seeking redemption and holiness. In Kundun, close-up shots of bronze Buddha sculptures recur throughout the film, emphasizing this search for holiness through aesthetic and symbolic repetition.

Applying the concept of gaze – a look that a-historizes and disembodies itself and objectifies the contemplated object (class/ 4.3) – it could be analyzed that gazing at Dalai Lama and the temples is not Buddha, but Martin Scorsese himself while interviewing Dalai Lama. Following mostly after close-ups of Dalai Lama, these images appear not only as an indication of Dalai Lama's legitimacy in being a mystical "chosen one" but also the image of seeing the personified god and purified land of Eden.

For "The Silent Holy Stone," can we honestly say that Pema

Tseden's Tibet escapes the mechanics of the gaze, or is it simply a gaze that turns inward – a self-reflexive, yet still constructed look? Pema Tseden's cinematic Tibet is not an "objective" reflection of reality but a mediated construction shaped by his subjective framing, compositional choices, and structured narratives. Throughout the film, unlike Kundun, which employs numerous moving shots and close-ups designed to provoke emotional responses from the audience immersed in the dark theater, Pema Tseden takes a different approach. He avoids emphasizing the protagonist's facial expressions, characterizing his cinematic style with restraint and composure. This approach breaks the imagination of a "mystical Tibet" and instead presents

the region through his lens of everyday life realism. However, this does not imply that Pema Tseden's representation of Tibet is an unmediated reality. On the contrary, it is still a carefully constructed cinematic reality that offers an alternative image of Tibet that resists romanticization and imagination while having a discussion around tradition and modernity.

Thus, the center of discussion lies not on whether reality is gazed upon or not but on who does the seeing and how the product of seeing mediates reality. Comparing the structure of "Kundun" and "The Silent Holy Stone," it's worth noting that both protagonists in the film encounter otherness that intrudes into their lives. For Dalai Lama, it is the communists invading their land, and for the little monk, it's the gradual modernization that seems to demystify the sacred, commercialize experience, and reduce belief to spectacle. Building upon this parallel, both "Kundun" and "The Silent Holy Stone" can be seen as narratives of resistance – each protagonist, in their own context, is confronting an otherness that unsettles their world's spiritual and cultural fabric. The "otherness" here—whether in the form of political violence or modernization—is not just an external threat but a force that reveals inner truths. Through their encounters with this otherness, the films do not simply document loss or intrusion; they visualize a struggle to preserve meaning, to re-enchant the sacred within a transforming world. The sacred, then, is activated and made perceptible through contrast and conflict.

To prevent the discussion from falling again into the dualism of sacred and secular that mystifies the transcendence and reduces it to abstract symbolism, an overarching implication is needed to clarify the sacred product of cinematic sites. To interpret from Professor Angela Zito's essay announcing that "we should examine how media practices make experiences and values 'sacred' (Zito, 2007)," theologies, doctrines, and religious symbols in films are all supplementary

material to produce the cinematic sacredness. In this view, the sacred is not a fixed theological being waiting to be discovered and gazed upon, but something dynamically constructed through cinematic form using sound, image, narrative, etc. Martin Scorsese represents and revitalizes Tibet in Morocco through cinematic constructions that place the audiences in the lost world of Tibet and thus proves to American audiences (though Disney is discouraged from screening publicly the film due to forces from the Chinese government) that there could be an oriental magic land existing with them. Comparatively, Pema Tseden captures in-depth the reality of Tibetan people's lives and proves to Chinese audiences that a truth-bearing character – the little monk – can take the essence and discard the useless from the incoming modernism wave. Through the construction of these cinematic worlds, shaped by each director's perceived reality, the film functions not merely as a reflector of religious tradition but as an active site where sacred meaning is invented and reconfigured. In this way, cinema emerges as a medium of modern religion – an art form born of modernity participating in the continual reinvention of society.

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